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GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

# Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy

*International Society of Equity Analysts*

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| <b>RELATED DOCUMENTS</b>  | Ethics Policy<br>Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct<br>Complaints Policy<br>Disciplinary Policy<br>Whistleblower Policy<br>Privacy Policy<br>Membership Policy<br>Membership Regulations<br>Member Admission Framework<br>Conflict of Interest Policy |

*This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.*

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## 1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (“ISEA”) is committed to building and maintaining an equitable, diverse and inclusive professional community in which every individual is treated with dignity and respect, has equal access to opportunity, and is able to participate fully in ISEA’s governance, membership, certification, professional development and other activities, free from discrimination, harassment, bullying and victimisation.

This Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy (“EDI Policy” or “Policy”) sets out ISEA’s position on equal opportunity, discrimination, harassment, bullying, victimisation, accessibility and the fair treatment of applicants and Members. It establishes the principles, standards and responsibilities that ISEA expects of all persons within its professional community, and the mechanisms by which those principles are implemented, monitored and enforced.

ISEA recognises that equality, diversity and inclusion (“EDI”) are not only matters of ethical and legal obligation, but also fundamental to the quality, objectivity and credibility of equity research and investment analysis. A profession that draws on a genuinely diverse range of perspectives, backgrounds and experience is better placed to identify risk, challenge assumptions, avoid groupthink and serve the interests of investors and markets worldwide.

This Policy operates alongside, and should be read together with, ISEA’s Ethics Policy, Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct, and other applicable ISEA policies, regulations and governance requirements.

## 2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to all persons participating in ISEA’s activities and governance, including:

- Governing Council members;
- Secretary-General and members of the Executive Secretariat;
- officers, committee chairs and committee members;
- Members (Student Members, Associate Members, Members and Fellows);
- applicants for ISEA membership, certification or designation, at every stage of the admission, assessment and onboarding process;
- holders of ISEA professional certifications and designations;
- employees, secondees and contractors engaged by ISEA;
- volunteers, examiners, assessors, speakers, mentors and other representatives acting on behalf of ISEA; and
- delegates, sponsors, exhibitors and other participants at ISEA-organised or ISEA-sanctioned conferences, examinations, chapter meetings and events.

This Policy applies to conduct occurring in connection with ISEA activities, wherever conducted, including in person, in writing, online, on ISEA digital platforms and social media, and at ISEA-sanctioned events, chapter meetings, examinations, committee meetings and Governing Council proceedings. It also applies to conduct outside those settings where it has a material connection to ISEA, its Members or its reputation.

Because ISEA operates as a multinational professional association with Members, chapters, examination centres and activities across many jurisdictions, this Policy is intended to reflect internationally recognised equality and human rights principles and to operate consistently with, and not in substitution for, the mandatory equality, anti-discrimination, employment and human rights laws applicable in the jurisdictions in which ISEA, its chapters or its Members operate. Where local law imposes a higher standard of protection than this Policy, the higher standard shall apply to activities within that jurisdiction. Nothing in this Policy is intended to require conduct that would breach applicable local law.

This Policy does not form part of, and does not vary, any contract of employment or engagement. Employment-related matters arising under this Policy will additionally be governed by applicable local employment law and any separate ISEA human resources policies.

### 3. Definitions

For the purposes of this Policy:

- “Protected Characteristic” means a personal characteristic that is protected from discrimination under this Policy, including age, race, colour, ethnic or national origin, ancestry, citizenship or immigration status, caste, sex, gender, gender identity or expression, sexual orientation, marital or civil partnership status, pregnancy or parental status, religion or belief, disability, health status, veteran or military status, socio-economic or educational background, political opinion (except where this would conflict with ISEA’s political neutrality requirements), and any other characteristic protected under applicable local law.
- “Discrimination” means treating a person less favourably because of a Protected Characteristic, or applying a provision, criterion or practice that disadvantages persons who share a Protected Characteristic without objective and reasonable justification, as further described in Section 7.
- “Harassment” means unwanted or unwelcome conduct that has the purpose or effect of violating a person’s dignity or creating an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. Harassment may be verbal, physical, written, visual or otherwise communicated, and may occur as a single incident or as a pattern of conduct. Harassment may be related to a Protected Characteristic or be of a sexual nature, but is not limited to such conduct, as further described in Section 8
- “Bullying” means repeated, unreasonable behaviour directed at an individual or group that creates a risk to health, safety, dignity or wellbeing, whether or not related to a Protected Characteristic, as further described in Section 9.
- “Victimisation” means subjecting a person to a detriment because they have made, supported, or participated in good faith in a complaint, report or proceeding under this Policy, as further described in Section 10.
- “Reasonable Accommodation” means an adjustment or modification to a process, requirement, facility or environment that removes or reduces a disadvantage experienced by a person because of disability or another relevant characteristic, provided it does not impose a disproportionate or undue burden on ISEA.
- “Applicant” means a person applying for Student Membership, Associate Membership, Membership, Fellowship, an ISEA certification or designation, or another ISEA opportunity such as a committee position, volunteer role or speaking engagement.
- “Unconscious Bias” means an implicit or unintentional assumption or stereotype about a person or group, formed outside conscious awareness, that may nonetheless influence judgement or decision-making if unchecked.
- “Micro-aggression” means a subtle, often unintentional, comment or action that conveys a negative, dismissive or stereotyping message about a person’s Protected Characteristic, and which may contribute to a hostile or exclusionary environment where it forms part of a repeated pattern.
- “EDI Committee” means the Executive Secretariat, unless and until the Governing Council appoints another Committee to perform the functions of the Executive Secretariat or establishes a new Committee for that purpose.

## 4. Policy Statement and Commitment

ISEA is committed to:

- providing equal opportunity to all persons who engage with ISEA, on the basis of merit, competence and conduct, without regard to any Protected Characteristic;
- maintaining a professional community that is free from discrimination, harassment, bullying and victimisation;
- ensuring that its governance, membership, certification, examination, committee and event processes are fair, transparent and accessible;
- promoting the representation and advancement of under-represented groups within the global equity research profession, consistent with applicable law;
- providing reasonable accommodation to Members, Applicants, employees and other participants who require adjustments because of disability or other relevant circumstances;
- fostering a culture in which individuals feel able to raise concerns without fear of retaliation; and
- holding all persons within its professional community accountable for upholding these commitments.

This commitment is championed at the highest level of ISEA's governance. The Governing Council, Secretary-General and the Executive Secretariat are responsible for promoting a culture of equality, diversity and inclusion throughout ISEA's global operations, and for ensuring that adequate resources, governance structures and accountability mechanisms are in place to give effect to this Policy.

## 5. Diversity and Inclusion as an Organisational Value

ISEA regards diversity and inclusion as integral to the quality and integrity of equity research and to the effective functioning of ISEA as a global professional body.

### 5.1 Diversity

ISEA values diversity in its broadest sense, encompassing differences in nationality, culture, language, ethnicity, gender, age, sexual orientation, disability, religion or belief, socio-economic background, educational pathway, career stage and professional experience. ISEA seeks to reflect this diversity within its Governing Council, committees, certification holders, membership base and Executive Secretariat, to the extent consistent with merit-based selection and applicable law.

### 5.2 Inclusion

ISEA is committed to fostering an inclusive environment in which every individual feels respected, valued and able to contribute fully. Inclusion means actively removing barriers to participation, encouraging diverse perspectives in decision-making, and ensuring that ISEA's culture, communications, events and digital platforms are welcoming to all.

### 5.3 Equity

ISEA recognises that treating all individuals identically does not always produce fair outcomes. Where appropriate and consistent with applicable law, ISEA will take proportionate steps to address disadvantage and to ensure that individuals from different backgrounds have genuinely equal access to ISEA's opportunities, including through Reasonable Accommodation, fee concessions, mentoring and outreach initiatives referred to in Section 15.

## 6. Equal Opportunity

ISEA is committed to equal opportunity in all aspects of its activities, including membership admission, certification and examinations, committee and volunteer appointments, employment and engagement, procurement, and participation in ISEA events and professional development.

### **6.1 Merit-Based Decision-Making**

Decisions concerning membership admission, certification, examination results, committee appointments, employment, promotion, speaking opportunities and recognition shall be based on relevant, objective and job- or role-related criteria, such as competence, qualifications, experience, conduct and performance, and shall not be influenced by any Protected Characteristic.

### **6.2 Equal Access**

ISEA shall take reasonable steps to ensure that its membership criteria, examination arrangements, fee structures, committee selection processes and events are designed and administered in a manner that provides equal access to persons of different backgrounds, subject to Reasonable Accommodation as described in Section 11.

### **6.3 Positive Action**

Where permitted by applicable law, ISEA may adopt proportionate positive action measures, such as targeted outreach, scholarships, mentoring programmes or diversity targets for committee composition, to address under-representation and to broaden participation in the equity research profession. Such measures are intended to expand opportunity and shall not result in the appointment or admission of a less qualified candidate over a more qualified candidate on the basis of a Protected Characteristic.

## **7. Non-Discrimination**

ISEA prohibits discrimination on the basis of any Protected Characteristic in connection with its activities, including membership admission, certification, examinations, committee and volunteer appointments, employment and engagement, and participation in ISEA events.

### **7.1 Protected Characteristics**

The Protected Characteristics recognised under this Policy include, but are not limited to, those listed in the definition of “Protected Characteristic” in Section 3. ISEA recognises that the specific characteristics protected by law vary between jurisdictions, and this Policy is intended to apply the broadest applicable protection, subject to Section 2.

### **7.2 Direct Discrimination**

Direct discrimination occurs where a person is treated less favourably than another person is, or would be, treated in a comparable situation, because of a Protected Characteristic. Examples include declining a membership application, denying access to an examination, or excluding a person from a committee opportunity because of a Protected Characteristic rather than their qualifications or conduct.

### **7.3 Indirect Discrimination**

Indirect discrimination occurs where an apparently neutral policy, criterion or practice disadvantages persons who share a Protected Characteristic, when compared with other persons, and cannot be objectively justified by a legitimate aim pursued by proportionate means. ISEA will keep its policies, criteria and practices under review to identify and remove any unjustified indirect discriminatory effect.

### **7.4 Discrimination in Membership and Certification**

Membership admission, certification and examination decisions shall be made solely by reference to the criteria set out in ISEA’s Membership Policy, Membership Regulations, Member Admission Framework and applicable certification requirements. No Applicant shall be refused admission, certification or examination access because of a Protected Characteristic.

### **7.5 Discrimination in Employment and Engagement**

ISEA is an equal opportunity employer and engager of contractors, volunteers and examiners. Recruitment, selection, remuneration, performance management, promotion, training and termination decisions shall be made on objective, role-related criteria and without regard to any Protected Characteristic, subject to and consistent with applicable local employment law.

## 8. Harassment

ISEA is committed to a professional environment free from harassment of any kind.

### 8.1 What Constitutes Harassment

Harassment may take many forms and may arise in any context in which individuals interact in connection with ISEA. The assessment of whether conduct constitutes harassment will have regard to the nature and circumstances of the conduct, its impact on the person concerned and all relevant circumstances, rather than solely to the intention of the person responsible.

A person's claim that conduct was intended as a joke, criticism, expression of opinion or otherwise harmless does not, by itself, prevent the conduct from constituting harassment. Harassment may consist of a single serious incident or a pattern of behaviour, and may occur in person, in writing, electronically, or through ISEA digital platforms and social media.

Examples of conduct that may constitute harassment include, but are not limited to:

- offensive, derogatory or demeaning remarks, jokes or imagery relating to a Protected Characteristic;
- unwanted physical contact, or conduct of an intimidating or threatening physical nature;
- displaying, circulating or posting offensive material, including online or via ISEA digital communications channels;
- persistent unwanted attention, including online contact, following a request that it stop; and
- mocking, mimicking or belittling a person's accent, cultural background, disability or other Protected Characteristic.

### 8.2 Sexual Harassment

Sexual harassment is unwanted conduct of a sexual nature that violates a person's dignity or creates an intimidating, hostile, degrading, humiliating or offensive environment. It may include unwelcome sexual advances, requests for sexual favours, sexually suggestive comments, jokes or imagery, and unwanted physical contact of a sexual nature. ISEA treats sexual harassment as a serious form of misconduct, particularly where it involves an actual or perceived imbalance of power or influence, such as between an examiner and a candidate, a mentor and a mentee, or a supervisor and a subordinate.

### 8.3 Harassment via Digital Communications and Social Media

This Policy extends to conduct on ISEA-managed digital platforms, discussion forums, virtual events and social media, and to communications made using an ISEA email address, membership designation or affiliation. Members and other persons subject to this Policy should exercise professional judgement when referencing ISEA or engaging with other Members online, and should not use such channels to harass, demean or intimidate others.

### 8.4 Harassment by Third Parties

ISEA will take reasonable steps to protect Members, employees, volunteers and other participants from harassment by third parties encountered in connection with ISEA activities, such as venue staff, sponsors, exhibitors or event attendees who are not themselves ISEA Members, and will address such concerns through the reporting channels described in Section 16, including, where appropriate, by engaging the relevant third-party organisation.

## 9. Bullying

ISEA does not tolerate bullying, whether or not it is related to a Protected Characteristic. Bullying is repeated, unreasonable behaviour directed at an individual or group of individuals that creates a risk to their health, safety, dignity or professional wellbeing.

Examples of conduct that may constitute bullying include, but are not limited to:

- persistent, unwarranted criticism or public humiliation;

- shouting, aggressive behaviour or threats;
- deliberately excluding an individual from meetings, communications or professional opportunities without legitimate reason;
- setting unreasonable or deliberately unachievable expectations, or withholding information necessary for an individual to perform their role or responsibilities; and
- undermining an individual's professional credibility or standing through unfounded criticism, rumour or exclusion.

ISEA distinguishes bullying from the legitimate, fair and constructive exercise of authority, such as reasonable performance management, appropriate feedback on examination or research submissions, or reasonable direction given by a committee chair, supervisor or examiner in the ordinary course of ISEA business.

Bullying can occur between peers, or can involve an actual or perceived imbalance of seniority, influence or authority, such as between a committee chair and a committee member, a senior Fellow and a Student Member, or an examiner and a candidate. ISEA treats bullying that exploits such an imbalance as a particularly serious matter. Bullying conducted through ISEA digital platforms, email or social media, including the persistent public criticism or belittling of an individual's professional work, is treated no less seriously than bullying that occurs in person.

## 10. Victimisation

ISEA prohibits victimisation of any person because they have, in good faith:

- made or supported a complaint or report under this Policy, the Whistleblower Policy or another applicable ISEA policy;
- provided information or evidence in connection with an investigation or disciplinary process;
- opposed conduct that they reasonably believed to be discriminatory, harassing, bullying or otherwise contrary to this Policy; or
- supported another individual in raising a concern under this Policy.

Victimisation may include, but is not limited to, adverse treatment such as exclusion from committees or opportunities, unfavourable changes to responsibilities, denial of a benefit or opportunity to which the person would otherwise be entitled, or renewed harassment or bullying. Victimisation is treated by ISEA as a serious matter and may result in disciplinary action in accordance with Section 19, independently of the outcome of the underlying complaint. A complaint that is not upheld will not, of itself, be treated as having been made in bad faith, and shall not give rise to victimisation of the person who made it, provided it was made honestly and in good faith.

## 11. Accessibility and Reasonable Accommodation

ISEA is committed to ensuring that its membership, certification, governance and event processes are accessible to persons with disabilities and other individuals who may require adjustments to participate fully.

### 11.1 Digital Accessibility

ISEA will take reasonable steps, having regard to applicable international accessibility standards and good practice, to ensure that its website, membership portals, examination platforms and digital communications are accessible to persons with disabilities, including through compatibility with commonly used assistive technologies where reasonably practicable.

### 11.2 Physical Accessibility

Where ISEA organises or sanctions in-person events, examinations, conferences or chapter meetings, it will take reasonable steps to select venues that are physically accessible and to provide accessible facilities, having regard to the needs notified by attendees and the practical and financial constraints applicable to the event.

### **11.3 Reasonable Accommodation in Examinations and Assessment**

Applicants and candidates who require Reasonable Accommodation in connection with an ISEA examination or assessment, such as extended time, accessible examination formats, a quiet testing environment, or the use of assistive technology, may request such accommodation through the process established by the relevant certification body or Executive Secretariat. Requests will be considered on an individualised basis, having regard to supporting documentation where reasonably required, the nature of the accommodation sought, and the need to maintain the integrity and validity of the assessment.

### **11.4 Reasonable Accommodation in Meetings and Events**

Governing Council members, committee members, employees, volunteers and Members participating in ISEA meetings and events may request Reasonable Accommodation, such as accessible materials, sign language interpretation, dietary accommodation, or flexible participation arrangements including remote or hybrid attendance where feasible.

### **11.5 Assessing Requests**

ISEA will assess each request for Reasonable Accommodation individually, in a timely and constructive manner, and in consultation with the person concerned. ISEA is not required to provide an accommodation that would impose a disproportionate or undue burden, taking into account factors such as cost, practicability, the availability of alternatives, and any impact on the integrity of an examination or assessment, but will give genuine consideration to reasonable alternatives before declining a request.

### **11.6 Neurodiversity, Mental Health and Wellbeing**

ISEA recognises that neurodivergent individuals, and individuals experiencing mental health conditions, may benefit from Reasonable Accommodation, such as adjusted communication formats, additional processing time, or alternative meeting or examination arrangements. ISEA encourages an inclusive culture in which individuals feel able to disclose such needs in confidence, without fear of disadvantage, and will handle any disclosure in accordance with Section 22.

### **11.7 Language and Communication Accessibility**

ISEA operates internationally and recognises that English proficiency varies across its global membership. Where reasonably practicable, ISEA will seek to make key membership, examination and governance information available in plain and clear language, and will consider requests for translation, interpretation or additional clarification in connection with ISEA processes, having regard to available resources and the need for consistency in examination administration.

## **12. Fair Treatment of Applicants and Members**

ISEA is committed to ensuring that Applicants and Members are treated fairly, consistently and transparently throughout their engagement with ISEA.

### **12.1 Membership Admission**

Membership admission decisions shall be made in accordance with the criteria and procedures set out in the Membership Policy, Membership Regulations and Member Admission Framework, applied consistently and without regard to any Protected Characteristic. Any discretionary element of the admission process shall be exercised in a manner consistent with this Policy and shall be capable of objective explanation.

### **12.2 Certification and Examinations**

Certification and examination processes shall be administered fairly and consistently, with clear, published eligibility criteria, standardised assessment procedures, and Reasonable Accommodation available in accordance with Section 11. Examination integrity and the comparability of results across candidates shall be maintained at all times.

### **12.3 Committee Appointments and Volunteer Opportunities**

Appointments to the Governing Council, committees and other volunteer or representative roles shall be based on relevant skills, experience, conduct and the needs of ISEA, applied through a transparent process. ISEA encourages diverse participation in its governance and committee structures, consistent with Section 6.3.

### **12.4 Events, Conferences and Professional Development**

Access to ISEA conferences, chapter meetings, webinars, mentoring programmes and other professional development opportunities shall be offered on a fair and non-discriminatory basis, having regard to any eligibility criteria applicable to the specific opportunity, such as membership category or continuing professional development requirements.

### **12.5 Fair Process and Right to be Heard**

Where ISEA proposes to take an adverse decision materially affecting an Applicant's or Member's status, such as refusal of an application, denial of an accommodation request, or a disciplinary outcome, ISEA will apply the procedural fairness safeguards set out in its Membership Regulations, Complaints Policy and Disciplinary Policy, including an appropriate opportunity for the individual to be heard, prior to a final decision being made.

## **13. Responsibilities**

Upholding equality, diversity and inclusion is a shared responsibility across ISEA's governance, staff, membership and volunteer community.

### **13.1 Governing Council**

The Governing Council is ultimately responsible for approving this Policy, setting ISEA's strategic direction on equality, diversity and inclusion, ensuring adequate resourcing and governance oversight, and modelling the standards of conduct expected of all persons within ISEA's professional community.

### **13.2 Secretary-General and Executive Secretariat**

The Secretary-General, supported by the Executive Secretariat, is responsible for the day-to-day implementation of this Policy, including embedding EDI principles into ISEA's operational processes, membership systems, examination administration, employment practices, procurement and events, and for reporting to the Governing Council and the EDI Committee on implementation and outcomes.

### **13.3 Committees and Committee Chairs**

Committee chairs are responsible for ensuring that committee proceedings are conducted in a manner consistent with this Policy, that committee membership and participation opportunities are offered fairly, and that any concerns raised within a committee are addressed appropriately or escalated in accordance with Section 16.

### **13.4 Employees, Contractors and Volunteers**

Employees, contractors, examiners, assessors and volunteers acting on behalf of ISEA are responsible for conducting themselves in accordance with this Policy, completing any training required of their role, and reporting conduct that they reasonably believe to be inconsistent with this Policy.

### **13.5 Members**

All Members are responsible for treating other Members, Applicants, ISEA staff, volunteers and third parties with dignity and respect, for complying with this Policy in all ISEA-related activities, and for cooperating reasonably with any investigation conducted under this Policy.

### **13.6 Chapters and Chapter Leadership**

Where ISEA operates through local or regional chapters, chapter leaders are responsible for promoting and applying this Policy within their chapter's activities, meetings and events, for escalating concerns to the Executive Secretariat or EDI Committee in accordance with Section 16, and for adapting ISEA's EDI

initiatives, where appropriate, to reflect the cultural, linguistic and legal context of the jurisdiction in which the chapter operates, without derogating from the minimum standards established by this Policy.

## **14. EDI Governance and Oversight**

ISEA shall maintain an EDI Committee, reporting to the Governing Council, responsible for overseeing the implementation, monitoring and continuous improvement of this Policy.

The EDI Committee's responsibilities may include:

- advising the Governing Council on ISEA's equality, diversity and inclusion strategy and priorities;
- monitoring implementation of this Policy across ISEA's governance, membership, certification, employment and event functions;
- reviewing aggregated, anonymised diversity and inclusion data in accordance with Section 21;
- recommending positive action initiatives, training programmes and outreach activities;
- liaising with the Ethics & Professional Standards Committee on matters of overlap between this Policy and the Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct; and
- recommending amendments to this Policy in accordance with Section 24.

The EDI Committee does not itself determine individual complaints of discrimination, harassment, bullying or victimisation; such matters are addressed through the Complaints Policy and Disciplinary Policy in accordance with Sections 16 to 19 of this Policy. The EDI Committee may, however, be consulted on systemic issues arising from patterns of complaints, subject to appropriate confidentiality safeguards.

## **15. Positive Action and Inclusion Initiatives**

Consistent with Section 6.3, ISEA may adopt initiatives designed to broaden participation in the equity research profession and to support under-represented groups, where permitted by applicable law. Such initiatives may include:

- scholarships, fee concessions or fee waivers to improve access to ISEA membership, examinations and certification for candidates from under-represented or lower-income backgrounds;
- mentoring, sponsorship and leadership development programmes;
- targeted outreach to universities, professional networks and communities that are under-represented within the profession;
- diversity considerations in the composition of the Governing Council, committees and conference speaker panels, applied consistently with merit-based selection; and
- chapter-level initiatives designed to reflect the cultural, linguistic and demographic context of the relevant jurisdiction.

Positive action initiatives shall be designed and implemented in a manner consistent with applicable law in the relevant jurisdiction, and shall not result in the appointment, admission or advancement of a less qualified individual over a more qualified individual on the basis of a Protected Characteristic.

## **16. Reporting Concerns and Complaints**

ISEA encourages any person who experiences or witnesses conduct that they reasonably believe to be inconsistent with this Policy to raise the matter promptly.

### **16.1 Informal Resolution**

Where appropriate and where the individual feels safe and comfortable doing so, concerns may first be raised informally with the person concerned, a committee chair, a manager, or another appropriate ISEA representative, with a view to reaching an early and constructive resolution. Informal resolution is not appropriate for serious allegations, such as sexual harassment or repeated misconduct, which should be reported formally.

## 16.2 Formal Complaints

Formal complaints concerning discrimination, harassment, bullying or victimisation shall be made in accordance with ISEA's Complaints Policy. Complaints may be submitted to the Executive Secretariat, a designated EDI contact, or another channel identified in the Complaints Policy or Whistleblower Policy, and may be submitted by the person directly affected or by another person on their behalf, including anonymously where the Whistleblower Policy so permits.

## 16.3 What to Include

Where possible, a complaint should describe the conduct concerned, the individuals involved, the date(s) and location(s) of the conduct, and any supporting information or witnesses. ISEA recognises that individuals may not always be able to provide full details, particularly in the case of sensitive or traumatic incidents, and will not treat an incomplete report as a reason to decline to engage with a concern.

## 16.4 Support for Complainants

ISEA will treat all reports made under this Policy seriously, sensitively and with appropriate urgency, and will take reasonable steps to support the wellbeing of individuals involved in a complaint, including, where appropriate, by facilitating access to independent counselling or support services and by considering interim measures, such as adjusting reporting lines, meeting arrangements or event participation, pending resolution of the matter.

## 17. Protection Against Retaliation

ISEA prohibits retaliation against any person who, in good faith, reports a concern, makes a complaint, provides information, or participates in an investigation under this Policy. Retaliation is treated as victimisation under Section 10 and as a serious form of misconduct in its own right.

Protections against retaliation under this Policy operate alongside, and are reinforced by, the protections available under ISEA's Whistleblower Policy, which establishes additional protected reporting channels and safeguards for individuals who report suspected wrongdoing.

## 18. Investigation and Resolution

Formal complaints raised under this Policy will be investigated in accordance with ISEA's Complaints Policy and, where the matter proceeds to a disciplinary process, the Disciplinary Policy.

ISEA's investigation process is designed to provide:

- a prompt and proportionate response, having regard to the nature and seriousness of the allegation;
- an impartial investigation conducted by a person or persons free from material conflicts of interest;
- appropriate confidentiality, in accordance with Section 22;
- an opportunity for the person against whom an allegation is made to respond before any adverse finding is made against them; and
- a documented outcome, communicated to the relevant parties to the extent appropriate and consistent with applicable confidentiality and privacy requirements.

Where an investigation identifies a breach of this Policy, ISEA may take remedial action, disciplinary action in accordance with Section 19, or both, as appropriate to the circumstances.

## 19. Disciplinary Consequences

Conduct found to breach this Policy will be addressed in accordance with ISEA's Disciplinary Policy. Depending on the nature and severity of the conduct, and the role of the person concerned, possible outcomes may include:

- mandatory EDI training or coaching;

- a formal warning or reprimand;
- removal from a committee, examiner, volunteer or representative role;
- suspension or termination of membership, in accordance with the Membership Regulations;
- suspension or withdrawal of an ISEA certification or designation;
- exclusion from ISEA events, examinations or digital platforms for a defined or indefinite period;
- for employees and contractors, disciplinary action up to and including termination of employment or engagement, in accordance with applicable local law and ISEA's employment policies; and
- referral to a relevant regulatory, professional or law enforcement body, where appropriate.

Disciplinary outcomes will be proportionate to the nature, seriousness and context of the conduct, any pattern of prior conduct, and the position of trust or authority held by the person concerned.

## 20. Training and Awareness

ISEA will promote awareness and understanding of this Policy through appropriate training and communication, including:

- EDI training for Governing Council members, committee members and Executive Secretariat staff, to be completed upon appointment and refreshed periodically;
- guidance and induction materials for examiners, assessors and volunteers acting on behalf of ISEA;
- awareness materials for Members, made available through ISEA's website, membership communications and continuing professional development channels; and
- targeted training for individuals in roles carrying particular responsibility for receiving or investigating complaints under this Policy.

Persons who fail, without reasonable excuse, to complete training required of their role may be subject to appropriate action in accordance with the relevant governance, employment or membership requirements applicable to that role.

## 21. Monitoring, Data Collection and Reporting

ISEA will monitor the implementation and effectiveness of this Policy, including through:

- periodic, voluntary and anonymised diversity monitoring of membership, certification candidates, committee composition and Governing Council composition, where permitted by applicable law;
- tracking of the number, nature and outcome of complaints raised under this Policy, reported to the EDI Committee in aggregated and anonymised form;
- periodic review of membership, examination, employment and event data to identify any unexplained disparities that may warrant further inquiry; and
- periodic reporting to the Governing Council on EDI progress, initiatives and outcomes.

Any diversity data collected under this Policy will be collected on a voluntary basis wherever practicable, will be processed in accordance with ISEA's Privacy Policy and applicable data protection law, and will be used only for the purposes of monitoring, reporting and improving equality, diversity and inclusion outcomes, and not for the purpose of making individual admission, certification, employment or disciplinary decisions.

Where practicable and useful, ISEA may benchmark its EDI monitoring data and initiatives against comparable professional associations and recognised international frameworks, in order to identify good practice and areas for improvement. Aggregated, non-identifying EDI metrics may be referenced in ISEA's annual or governance reporting, at the discretion of the Governing Council.

## 22. Confidentiality and Privacy

ISEA will handle information relating to concerns, complaints and investigations raised under this Policy with appropriate confidentiality, disclosing information only to those persons who reasonably need to know it in order to progress a report, conduct an investigation, ensure procedural fairness, or comply with a legal obligation.

Personal information collected in connection with this Policy will be processed in accordance with ISEA's Privacy Policy and applicable data protection law. ISEA will seek to balance the confidentiality interests of all parties with the requirements of procedural fairness, the need to conduct an effective investigation, and any applicable legal or regulatory obligations.

## 23. Relationship with Other ISEA Policies

This Policy operates alongside, and should be interpreted consistently with, other ISEA policies, including:

- the Ethics Policy and Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct, which establish ISEA's broader ethical framework;
- the Complaints Policy, which establishes the process for submitting and handling complaints;
- the Disciplinary Policy, which establishes procedures for investigating and resolving alleged breaches of ISEA requirements;
- the Whistleblower Policy, which establishes protected channels for reporting suspected wrongdoing and safeguards against retaliation;
- the Privacy Policy, which governs the handling of personal information;
- the Membership Policy, Membership Regulations and Member Admission Framework, which govern membership eligibility, admission and status; and
- the Conflict of Interest Policy, which applies where a conflict of interest arises in connection with a matter addressed by this Policy.

Where a matter is addressed by a specific procedure established by one of these policies, that procedure shall apply, together with the substantive standards established by this Policy.

## 24. Third-Party Contractors, Suppliers and Event Partners

ISEA expects contractors, suppliers, venues, sponsors, exhibitors and other third parties engaged in connection with ISEA activities to conduct themselves consistently with the principles of this Policy while engaged in that connection.

Where reasonably practicable, ISEA will:

- include appropriate EDI expectations in contracts and event agreements with venues, suppliers, sponsors and exhibitors;
- select event venues and suppliers with appropriate regard to accessibility, as described in Section 11.2;
- make clear to third parties that conduct inconsistent with this Policy, including harassment of Members, staff or volunteers, may result in termination of the relevant arrangement; and
- provide a channel, consistent with Section 16, through which Members, staff or volunteers may report concerns about the conduct of a third party encountered in connection with ISEA activities.

This Policy does not itself govern the internal employment or diversity practices of independent third-party organisations, but ISEA will take reasonable and proportionate steps, within the scope of its contractual relationships, to promote consistency with the principles of this Policy.

## **25. Illustrative Examples**

The following examples are provided to assist understanding of this Policy. They are illustrative only, are not exhaustive, and do not predetermine the outcome of any particular case, which will depend on its specific facts and circumstances.

### **25.1 Membership Admission**

An Applicant is refused Associate Membership on the stated basis that ISEA “prefers candidates from more traditional financial backgrounds.” If the Applicant otherwise meets the published admission criteria, this would raise a concern of discrimination on the basis of socio-economic or educational background and should be reported in accordance with Section 16.

### **25.2 Examination Accommodation**

A candidate with a documented visual impairment requests an accessible examination format and additional time. Provided the request is properly evidenced, ISEA would generally be expected to provide Reasonable Accommodation under Section 11.3, absent a specific and substantial concern regarding the integrity of the assessment, which should itself be explained to the candidate.

### **25.3 Conduct at a Conference**

At an ISEA-sanctioned conference, a senior Fellow repeatedly makes demeaning jokes about a junior analyst’s nationality in front of other attendees. This conduct is capable of constituting harassment under Section 8, regardless of whether the senior Fellow considered the comments to be humorous, and may be reported under Section 16.

### **25.4 Retaliation After a Complaint**

A committee member who raised a good-faith concern about a colleague’s conduct is subsequently excluded from committee communications and denied a speaking opportunity previously offered to them. This may constitute victimisation under Section 10 and should be reported promptly.

## **26. Review and Continuous Improvement**

ISEA shall periodically review this Policy to ensure that it remains appropriate, effective and consistent with developments in:

- international human rights and equality standards and good practice;
- applicable law in the jurisdictions in which ISEA, its chapters and its Members operate;
- the composition, needs and expectations of ISEA’s global membership; and
- the evolving needs of the equity research profession.

The EDI Committee shall recommend amendments to this Policy where appropriate, having regard to monitoring data collected under Section 21, complaint trends, and feedback from Members and stakeholders, subject to approval by the Governing Council.

## **27. Effective Date**

This Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Policy takes effect on the date approved by the Governing Council.